

will only increase in times to come, and Android will continue to grow at an even faster pace. So, great hardware, unique apps and after sales service would be the only differentiators in the future."

Interestingly, Lava has made the move into a higher market segment with the Iris Pro, even though the company already has its Xolo brand for premium products. Speaking about this, Rai explains, "While Xolo does deal with premium products, it doesn't mean that Lava can't do the same. In the market, both the ranges from the Lava company are separate, and there could be a time when both brands compete with each other. While Lava is playing the market from a low to very high level, Xolo is playing only at the higher level."

When Lava originally launched the Xolo brand, it was in order to have a premium device at a higher price point. Rai explains that it would be difficult for consumers to relate to the Lava brand at that price point. He says that the company is improving one step at a time and has built a huge customer base.

The company eventually plans to go global and compete in various markets across the world. But Rai acknowledges that this is going to take Lava a long time. He feels the

company first has to consolidate itself at the Rs 20,000 level, where the Iris Pro series will be available. While the Iris Pro 30 is priced at Rs 15,999, there will be two other devices in the series soon, according to him.

Post consolidation, Lava needs to build the capability to make the products that consumers in the next (premium) segment will find relevant. Rai doesn't give an exact time frame, but admits that it would take a while. "I think it will take a long time. First, the Chinese brands are going to go global and do well, like they've done in China. And then it's going to be our turn. It's going to take time; it's not going to be very soon. But we're not in a hurry," he says. The company currently has a market share of 7 per cent in India. While it aims to increase its revenue by three times, Rai does not expect the market share to grow at the same rate.

So, Lava's strategy for the consumer market seems to be simple—to conquer one segment at a time. The company, which was known for producing sub-Rs 10,000 smartphones till now, has gone on to enter the middle or affordable segment. Lava is building what Rai calls 'delighted consumers', as it starts making plans for going global. **END** 

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